

Forgiving Others and Yourself

Use these pages only if writing is safe for you. If someone monitors your belongings or writing, do not create or keep anything that could place you at risk; pray without writing. Use an initial or no details. Nothing here is graded, collected or shown to anyone.

If any of this brings up more than you can hold, stop, and defer the session. That is a legitimate decision.

1 • Check-in (gently)

1. Is there a person whose actions still carry unresolved grief, anger, fear, or a desire for justice in you? Name them, or use an initial, or write nothing identifying.

2. Which of those responses needs grief, which needs protection, which needs accountability, and which may be moving toward release? Use the five movements.

3. Which parts of what you want depend on the other person? Which faithful steps remain available to you even if they never respond as you hope?

4. Is there something you have been punishing yourself for that God has already forgiven, or that you have never brought to him?

3 • Silence

Ten minutes, or the length you can manage. Anchor phrase: “Into your hands I place this wound.” Or: “God sees and God cares.” Or: “Show me the next faithful step.” If the silence brings the person too close, stop, open your eyes, and use the orientation exercise from Lesson 5.

4 • Journal

1. What happened in the silence? Write it without interpreting it.

2. Which of the “release is not” statements did you most need to hear? Which have you been confusing with forgiveness, and how has that confusion kept you from it?

3. What safety measure, boundary, report, or consequence will remain in place whatever you release? Write it down if it is safe and helpful, or simply reflect on it. Naming it may make release possible.

4. If you have been punishing yourself, which of the four (conviction, shame, consequence, self-punishment) is actually at work? What would it mean to accept Romans 8:1 as the verdict?

5 • The default prayer

Write only this, or pray it without writing, and let it be the whole exercise:

God, I place this wound in your care and ask for help with the next faithful step.

Optional further stage, only if you are ready and safe

Writing, sealing and keeping the card are all optional. Write on an index card, not on this page:

Today, as far as I am able, I release personal vengeance and place justice in God's hands.

This does not surrender safety, truth, restitution, reporting, or lawful accountability.

I do not promise what I cannot yet give.

If the pain returns, I will not assume this prayer failed; I will ask whether I need lament, support, protection, treatment, or renewed trust.

I ask for help with the next faithful step.

If Session 5 left you with something to release in yourself, a second card:

God has forgiven _____.

I have been responding through _____.

Help me distinguish faithful accountability from self-punishment.

What repair is mine, I will pursue.

What suffering I am using as payment, help me release.

6 • Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

I am not required to deny the wrong or abandon justice.

I release, or ask for help releasing, personal vengeance.

I will preserve the boundaries, truth, reporting, and accountability that remain necessary.

I place what I cannot control into God's care.

God's mercy does not require me to remain in danger.